



AMAR'S AT HOME
Left and below, inside the Amar Nath Sehgal private collection in Delhi; bottom, a sculpture in the grounds

ART

Time **Capsule**



THE NEWLY OPENED **AMAR NATH SEHGAL PRIVATE COLLECTION** IN DELHI'S JANGPURA EXTENSION IS A MUSEUM FOCUSED ON A SINGLE ARTIST WHICH IMMERSES THE VISITOR IN HIS LIFE AND TIMES

Shortly after India's independence, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru was travelling in the US, encouraging young Indians—engineers, doctors, artists—to come back to help build a newly independent nation. One of them, prowling around the East Village, finding his voice and yet missing home, was the young Amar Nath Sehgal. Nehru promised him a piece of land for his studio in the neighbourhood of Jangpura in Delhi if he returned. The artist asked that it be a corner plot, to maximise light and view. This request was admitted, and that plot, home and workspace to the artist for four decades now houses the Amar Nath Sehgal Private Collection. It is a quietly successful attempt to bring an artist's life and work into conversation with its surroundings, both past and present. The multi-media display is deftly curated for what is said to be the first and only single-artist museum in the country. Entering the space, one is quickly immersed in the life and times of the modern artist, sculptor, poet and engaged humanist. Despite this, the museum feels strikingly contemporary.

The space is intimate, spread over a ground, mezzanine and first floor. An informative guided tour with the curator in residence reiterates that the space has been renovated to stay true to the way the artist used and worked in the studio, where he had his worktable, his day bed, his dark room, his gallery space. The exhibits are exhaustive and diverse, spanning time, medium, preoccupation, style. You can take a chronological walk through the artist's life, from his childhood in pre-Partition Lahore, his lifelong memories of Partition, his escape from a new home in Delhi to the US to find and hone his artistic voice, and the decades of varied artistic engagement and production that followed, between India, Europe and the US. The display moves consistently between what was happening in his world—emotionally or materially—and his sketches, moulds and then emergent art. Sehgal moved between home and abroad for space and exposure; he survived as an artist by accepting commissions for public institutions, industrialists and political patrons. If it is Sehgal's evolving practice that is of greater interest than his biography, it is also possible to stay with the shifting forms of his sculpture, between figurative and abstract, conceptual and determinedly ideological. Well-known pieces like 'Cries Unheard', 'Anguished Cries', and 'The Captive', which channel his memories

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